Red

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Red.

Red like rings of fire.

Red like the meat dangling over my mouth.

Red like the whip, cracking down like thunder.

Red like blood bursting through my split skin.

Red like the haze that covered my vision.

Red like the ringmaster's coat, shining under the lamps.

Red like my teeth, stained with the relish of biting down deep and hard.

Red like his scream as he stumbled back.

Red like the fabric of the velvet curtains swinging in the wind.

Red like the clang of a bell, calling for the chains and the cage.

Red like escape.

I burst through the wall of the tent, tumbling head over tail. The world outside spun. Lanterns bobbed in the air. Music shrieked from horns. A cacophony of lights and sounds, blaring and blinking. Colors and cheers and chatter. The silky smell of sugar polluted the air, thick enough to choke on. I staggered forward, drunk on terror.

A scream sliced through the atmosphere. I turned my head, ears alert, towards the source.

A woman stood frozen, pointing directly at me, her whole body enveloped with fear. A beat of silence. Time stood still. Everyone in the vicinity turned to look at me.

The world erupted. Chaos everywhere. The magic of the carnival dissolved into yells and stampedes, boots thundering against the earth. Amidst the blur of people, men in red came charging towards me.

Red. Red was bad. Red was evil.

As the men came closer, shouting harsh commands, I did the only thing I could think of. I ran. Into inky-black forest, into dark night, away from the lights and smells and sounds of the circus. Trees blurred past in jagged streaks. The cold sliced my lungs. Only when my legs buckled underneath me did I dare to look back.

No whips. No cages. No red. Nothing but pitch-black night surrounded me. I collapsed into the ground and let sleep claim me.

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Morning brought hunger, hunger like nothing else I could imagine. The sharp pangs in my underbelly jerked me awake and alert. Warily treading through the forest, I looked for anything worth eating while the little voice in my stomach screamed at me to hurry up. After hours of wandering, I almost felt like giving up.

But then I saw it; a little flash of red out of the corner of my eye.

I drew back on instinct. The red seemed to be still. After a few seconds of waiting, curiosity overruled fear and I slowly began creeping towards the red, still ready to tuck my tail between my legs and run away. Every second felt like an eternity. I could feel my heavy breaths

and my heart beating in anticipation of discovering what the red was. But as soon as I got within a few feet of it, it disappeared. It was just… gone. Nothing but shrubbery and tree trunks to be seen. Disoriented, I spun around wildly trying to see where the red went. As soon as I started to calm down, a loud voice erupted.

"Boo!" a playful voice came from behind me as something light landed on my back. As a reflex, I immediately turned around. Nothing was there. Where could the voice have come from? "Over here!" that same raspy voice called, now to my left. I spun around again to empty green grass, no red to spot in sight. "Yoo-hoo!" the teasingly sing-songy voice came from behind me again. Now I was getting angry. I bared my teeth, and, after preparing myself, I turned around and ran in the direction of the voice, as fast as my legs would take me. But still nothing.

"Okay, okay, I'll come clean," the voice said. "It was me." Coming out from behind a tree, the most fiery-red thing I had ever seen trotted into view. It was like me, but smaller and lighter. I froze. "Easy, easy, I'm not gonna hurt'cha," the fox said. "So who are ya? Haven't seen ya 'round here." I still didn't speak. "C'mon, you gotta be able to say something," the fox teased. "Just a tiny bark for a little foxy-woxy?" I was too scared to say anything. "You are able to speak, right?" the fox said, the playful grin on his face being replaced with a look of distrust. He came ever closer. "All wild animals can speak. Unless you're one of those circus breeds." He started sniffing my fur, the look on his face getting more and more disgusted by the second. "You are!" he growled. "You're one of those dirty, filthy, impure, tame, cir—"

"I'm not a circus breed!" I exclaimed. The fox drew back, surprised at my sudden outburst. The whole forest was silent for a few seconds, not even birds chirping. "I-they took me

from my home when I was young." I remembered the evil red men pulling me away from my den.

The fox lowered his head, as if empathetic. But then he immediately jumped up, more lively than ever. "You know what?" he said. "I'm almost sorry for ya. But your sob story doesn't matter to me enough for me to care." He drew closer to me. "Now, here's the deal, newbie," he growled. "This is our forest. We rule this place. You take one step into our territory and you'll wish you didn't." And with that, he started bounding away.

I didn't know what to do, but then instinct took over and I started running after the fox. "Wait!" I called. I huffed and puffed as I tried to follow his agile movements, my body filled with the fear of what he said. *I don't want to die here alone!* Suddenly, as I was trying to track the red blur in front of me, my front foot caught on a root. My body braced for impact as my face hit the wet dirt, and I crumpled to the ground.

I lay there for a minute, breathing heavily. The pangs in my stomach seemed stronger than ever, each nauseating wave begging me to eat something. Driven by the ounce of determination I had left, I began to slowly get up. My legs, now weak, shook as they tried to support the weight of my body. I started to lick the stinging cuts and scratches I had all over my body. The blood from my wounds was now matting my fur, making it sticky and clumpy. *This is nothing compared to the circus*, I thought. My thoughts drifted to that place, with its red whips and red fire and red blood. And the red fox, jumping around and taunting me. *All red must be gone*, I deliriously decided. *All red must die. Red is evil and bad and cruel.*

But first, I have to eat! Another wave ripped across my body. *I should have eaten the fox*, I thought bitterly. *Then at least that red would be gone.* Resigned to my fate, I began to walk around the forest, searching desperately for anything to eat. As soon as I was going to give up and think about returning to the circus, that same color—red— appeared in the furthest corner of my vision.

I drew back from instinct. Was it the fox coming to spit at me again? Was it one of those red men looking for me? I knew I shouldn't approach it, but I was too desperate not to. I carefully trod toward it, and this time I knew what it was. It was a little girl wearing a red hood! I'd recognize that raincoat anywhere. I saw it at all the shows in that circus, always that same little girl. She sat in the front row. I would always spot her looking at me and me only, ignoring the lions or the elephants, her eyes filled with wonder.

A flash of hot anger suddenly came over me. Did the girl not see how much I hated the circus? How much the red men were whipping me? She was just like the rest of them, I decided. She also needed to be gone. All red needed to be gone. I knew I wasn't able to think straight from hunger, but it was the only thing I could think of, and I was too desperate to do anything else.

So I invoked the last bit of strength I had left, and carefully followed the girl. Trotting carefully behind her, my heart beating faster than ever. I waited for the right moment where I could pounce. I was so focused on the girl, I didn't notice when my paw fell on a stick! A cracking sound filled the quiet forest, and the girl turned around. When she saw me, she froze, her eyes

filled with fear. I knew she recognized me. My mind raced, trying to find a way to get out of this. *I have to gain her trust!* I decided. *I* have to become her friend.

Immediately I adopted the friendliest look I could muster. “Where are you going, little girl?” I sweetly asked. The girl was paralyzed. “Don’t worry, I’m not going to bite you. You would taste much too bitter for me,” I lied, already imagining the sweet flesh tearing under my teeth. As her eyes stayed fixed on me, I knew I was losing her. I had to make her believe I liked her! “Don’t you remember me?” I asked with the biggest smile on my face. “I’m that little wolf from the circus! I wouldn’t harm anyone. I only followed you to protect you. There are some vicious animals in this forest. So, where are you going?” Her eyes softened, and I knew I had her.

“M-my grandmama's house,” she whispered. “I’m going to give this cake to her.” She pulled out a big cake from her woven basket, and my mouth watered as she lifted it in front of my eyes. *Resist!* I thought. *You will get to eat the cake* and *the girl if you are patient!* “That’s so sweet!” I gushed. My mind racing, I came up with a plan.

“You should also pick some flowers for her! I’m sure she would love them.”

The little girl’s eyes widened. “Flowers!” she exclaimed. “I never thought of those! I’m going to find some right now!” And with that she was off, happily pattering through the fallen leaves.

As soon as I was sure the little girl was gone, I knew I had to move quickly. I galloped on the path the girl was taking, hoping I would find something apart from trees and plants. After a few minutes of running, I spotted a small cottage in the distance! Filled with invigoration, I ran

even faster toward the cottage. My stomach growled fiercely, but I ignored it. Just a little longer, I told it. You'll get your reward soon. When I finally reached the cottage, I padded up to the front door and stood on my hind legs to turn the doorknob. That was one of the tricks they taught me in the circus. Well, now it was coming back to bite them.

The house seemed empty, but I knew I should still be cautious. I carefully walked through each room, on high alert of any movement. When I walked into what seemed like the bedroom, I carefully nudged around in every closet until I found what I was looking for. Clothes. I jumped up and grabbed a bonnet off of a shelf with my teeth, and then flipped in on top of my head. I snuffled around in the shelf, but I couldn't find anything else! No! I thought. How will she think I am her grandma if I am just wearing a bonnet? I ran out of the bedroom in a panic. When she sees me, she will surely run away! I looked through the whole house for any set of clothes, but I couldn't find any. Does this grandma only wear one pair of clothes? As I was looking through the shelves of the main room, I heard the thing I was dreading. The girl's footsteps! I knew if she saw me, she would scream, and those foxes, or some other animals, would surely hear it. I had to take her by surprise! In a panic, I did the only thing I could think of. I ran upstairs to the bedroom and inserted myself into the blankets, hoping for the best.

After a few moments, I heard the sound of the doorknob turning and the door creaking open. "Oh, grandmother!" came the girl's high voice. "I brought you a cake!"

"Is that you, my grandchild?" I called from the bed, trying to soften my voice as much as possible. "Come up here so I can see you." My stomach rumbled once more, and I knew it

would be the last time. I heard the pitter-patter of the girl lightly coming up the steps, and my mouth started to water.

The girl appeared in the doorway, looking jolly as ever. When her eyes fell upon me, she looked confused, but shrugged it off and came closer. “Hello, grandmother!” she cried. “How are you doing? Mamma told me you were ill.”

“Yes, I am very ill, child,” I lied. “That is why I look like this. Now put that cake upon the stool, and come get into bed with me.”

The girl unbuckled her little raincoat, and it fell to the floor. Without that evil red piece of clothing, she almost looked innocent again. I started to have second thoughts about eating her, but my stomach’s growl reminded me that I had no choice. As the girl climbed into bed, she looked at me in awe.

"Grandmother, what big arms you have!" she marveled.

“All the better to hug you with, my dear,” I responded.

“Grandmother, what big legs you have!”

“All the better to run with, my child,”

“Grandmother, what big ears you have!”

“All the better to hear with, my child.”

“Grandmother, what big eyes you have!”

“All the better to see with, my child.”

“Grandmother, what big teeth you have!”

It was time.

“All the better to eat you up with.”

I fell upon the little girl.

Red.